

**From:** Sachin Sharma [sachin.criticalcollective@gmail.com](mailto:sachin.criticalcollective@gmail.com)  
**Subject:** Fwd: Essays on Rajkummar Rao's middle-class masculinity, regional children's films, Kaifi Azmi's revolutionary romance and desire in P. Padmarajan's cinema  
**Date:** 27 July 2026 at 8:12 PM  
**To:** Ashwath Choyi Naroath [naroath@volo.llc](mailto:naroath@volo.llc)

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From: **Critical Collective** <[criticalcollective.in@36996441.mailchimpapp.com](mailto:criticalcollective.in@36996441.mailchimpapp.com)>

Date: Thu, May 14, 2026 at 11:52 AM

Subject: Essays on Rajkummar Rao's middle-class masculinity, regional children's films, Kaifi Azmi's revolutionary romance and desire in P. Padmarajan's cinema

To: <[sachin.criticalcollective@gmail.com](mailto:sachin.criticalcollective@gmail.com)>

CC  
CINEMA





(top) Still from *Stree* (2018)

Courtesy: D2R Films and Maddock Films

(bottom) Still from *Newton* (2017)

Courtesy: Drishyam Films

## The Ordinarity of Rajkummar Rao

By Sonal Jha

The hapless, vernacular protagonists portrayed by Rao echo the existential weight carried by middle-class men in a post-liberalized Indian economy, and present an alternative to violent masculine assertions in recent Hindi cinema.

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(top) Still from *Aatmapamphlet* (2023)

Courtesy: T-Series, Colour Yellow Productions and Zee Studios

(bottom) Still from *Boong* (2024)

Courtesy: Excel Entertainment

## What the Child Knows

By Rajlakshmi Bhagawati

Regional Indian cinema of the last decade has moved away from infantilizing representations of children to foregrounding them as figures who observe, resist and imagine their way through structural conflicts related to caste, gender, ecology, and militarization.

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(top) Still from *Naseem* (1995)

Courtesy: National Film Development Corporation of India

(bottom) Kaifi Azmi and Shama Zaidi on the sets of *Garm Hava* (1974)

Courtesy: Cameo Studios

## **Kaifi Azmi: Romancing the Revolution**

By Shivangi Jalan

From the *mushairas* of Lucknow to the film studios of Bombay, Azmi's writings carried the weight of a nation in flux, using the richness of Urdu literature to raise social consciousness and champion the cause of marginalized communities.

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(top) Poster of *Njan Gandharvan* (1991)

Courtesy: Wikimedia Commons

(bottom) Portrait of P. Padmarajan

Courtesy: Creative Commons

## **When Women Desire: Sexuality and Agency in P. Padmarajan's Films**

By Saraswathy K. Bhattathiri

Padmarajan's cinema exposes the instability of femininity and sexuality under patriarchy and unsettles binaries of virtue and transgression, while questioning whether cinematic language can move beyond male constructed frameworks of desire.

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